

The Fugitive King: The Story of David from Shepherd Boy to King Over God's Chosen People, Israel.

By Elizabeth Rice Handford

Chapter 1 A Kingdom is Lost

“We won! We won!” the jubilant soldiers shouted as they streamed into Gilgal. What a wonderful sight it was to see two- hundred thousand soldiers of Israel to march into camp, their flags flying, and dragging behind them the loot they had captured from the Amalekites!

It had been a desperate, bloody battle, and they hadn’t been sure they could win it. The Amalekites were fierce warriors. They fought like tigers. But God helped the Israelites, and they finally did whip their enemies. Then they went through the camp of the Amalekites. Everything that was old and shabby, they burned. But the beautiful, expensive things they saved to take home with them. They killed any of the cows and horses that looked thin or diseased, but they rounded all the sleek, fine cattle to drive them home. They killed most of the soldiers, but they captured King Agag, and they brought him home in chains.

They had good reason to be happy, not only because of the loot they’d taken, but also because the Amalekites had been their enemies for four hundred years, ever since the children of Israel had walked that weary way from Egypt back up to Canaan. The Israelites had put all the women and children at the very back of the line. They figured that the soldiers at the front of the line could stop any enemies, and keep the helpless children safe. But the crafty Amalekites waited until the soldiers had marched by. Then they attacked the helpless women and children. The only way the Israelites were able to beat them off was for Moses to hold his

hands high, while Joshua led the army to the attack. They fought them off, but God remembered the wicked thing the Amalekites had done. God promised the children of Israel that some He would pay them back.

Now at last, God was keeping that promise. Under King Saul the first king of Israel, the army had conquered their ancient enemy. The people shouted with joy as they saw King Saul lead the procession back to camp, dragging along snarling King Agag, like a dog on a leash. But when Saul got to the altar at Gilgal, a frown wiped the smile from his face. There stood the terrible figure of the aged prophet, Samuel. He had a terrible message from God to deliver to King Saul, and he dreaded giving it. King Saul pretended not to notice the angry expression on Samuel's face. "Greetings, Samuel!" he cried. "God bless you. I have done everything that God commanded me to do."

Samuel cocked his head, as if listening for something. What was it he was listening for, beyond the happy shouts of the soldiers and the people? He could hear the bleating of the sheep, and the lowing of the cattle which had been captured from the Amalekites! "If you had obeyed the voice of the Lord", Samuel answered, "What does this bleating of the sheep mean? And whose oxen are those that I hear lowing?"

Saul shrugged his shoulders. "They used to belong to the Amalekites. The people saved the best sheep and oxen so they can make a great sacrifice to God. We killed all the rest of the animals".

Samuel's dark eyes bored a hole into Saul's heart. "Saul, do you remember how you became king?"

Sure, he remembered! He'd been looking for his father's lost donkeys. He went to where the Prophet Samuel lived, to ask him if he could help find them. Samuel told him where they were, but then told him that God had chosen him to be Israel's first king. Saul was aghast. "Me? King of Israel? Oh, no, not me! I'm from the littlest tribe in Israel, and my family is the most unimportant family in the tribe. God couldn't want me to be a king." But Samuel assured him that was exactly God's plan. He anointed him with precious ointment, and pronounced him king. But when Samuel came to present Saul to all the people, he couldn't find him. Saul was so scared, he was hiding behind the baggage! Yes, Saul remembered how God made him king.

Samuel said, "When you were little in your own sight, God made you king over Israel. Now, did God give you a job to do?"

"Yes, Sir, He told me to kill the Amalekites."

"Why didn't you do it?"

"Oh, but I did. I destroyed almost everything. We just saved the best things to make a sacrifice to God."

“But, Saul, which does God want? Your sacrifices or your obedience?”

Saul hung his head.

Samuel continued, “Can’t you see it’s better to do exactly what God says, than it is to make Him a gift of anything in the world? God does not want your gifts if you do not obey Him.”

Saul scowled. “I was just trying to please Him.”

“O Saul,” Samuel said, “can’t you see you are really doing only what you want? Rebellion is as bad a sin before an idol to worship it.” Samuel’s voice dropped to a whisper, “Saul, because you have rejected the word of the Lord, He has rejected you from being king!”

“I’ve done wrong, I admit it”, Saul said. “I broke the commandment of the Lord because I was afraid of the people. But that’s not very important. Come on back, and make the sacrifice for me, so I won’t be embarrassed in front of the people.”

“Not important?” Samuel echoed. As Samuel turned away Saul grabbed his mantle and it tore. “Just like this mantle is torn, God has taken your kingdom away from you. He will give it to someone who is better than you. God doesn’t lie. He’s not a man. He won’t change His mind. He’s not a man. He won’t change His mind. You have lost the kingdom forever!”

You'd have thought, at such awful words, that King Saul would have fallen to his knees to say he was sorry. But he only tugged at Samuel's arm. "Please pretend to the people that everything is all right. Honor me before the people. Don't mess everything up. Please go ahead and make the sacrifice for me." So Samuel turned again after Saul and Samuel worshipped.

But Samuel had to carry out God's command. He had to do what King Saul should have done. He turned to the soldiers. "Bring King Agag here."

King Agag smirked when the soldiers came for him. Though he had murdered hundreds of innocent babies, he thought he was safe. "They won't kill me now," he thought. He walked prissily up to the Prophet Samuel.

"King Agag," Samuel said, "because you have killed thousands of innocent people, Gods has commanded that you die."

King Agag fell by Samuel's sword, and a four- hundred- year promise made by God had been kept.

King Saul marched back to his palace at Gibeah. If he was worried about what the Prophet Samuel had said, he didn't show it. It didn't seem to matter that he had disobeyed God, and led all the people to disobey Him as well.

The heartbroken Samuel went back to his home in Ramah. He never saw King Saul again, face to face. Samuel grieved day after day about King Saul. If Saul could not be king, who would lead the nation? It would take a giant of a man, strong, famous, powerful. Israel had many terrible enemies. They would need a great man to lead them. Samuel couldn't think of a single man in the whole kingdom who could do it!

But the loving, searching eye of God was on a little boy in a small town called Bethlehem, down on the south edge of the country. There were no visions of gold crowns or kingdoms in this child's bright mind. David, son of Jesse, was thinking about one thing: feeding his flock of hungry sheep.